

Dedan Kimathi University of Technology



School of Computer Science and IT

Department of Information Technology

BSc. Business Information Technology

Capstone Project

Photographic Essay: Youth Unemployment in African Communities

Grace Wanjiru Ndumbi

C027-01-1006/2022

Introduction

Youth unemployment is one of the most serious challenges facing many African communities today. Young people make up a large percentage of the population, and they are expected to be the driving force of economic growth and development. However, due to limited job opportunities, slow economic growth, and a mismatch between education and the labour market, many youths remain unemployed or underemployed (Ahmed, 2024; Mncwango & Adanlawo, 2025). Research shows that skill and educational mismatches are pervasive among African youth, reducing job satisfaction and increasing time spent searching for work (Mukasa, 2024). This situation affects not only individuals but also families and entire communities.

This photographic essay uses images to tell the story of youth unemployment, showing both the struggles faced by young people and the efforts being made to overcome this challenge. Through these photographs, the essay highlights the causes, effects, and possible solutions to youth unemployment in African societies.

Figure 1: Groups of Young People Sitting Idle



This image above represents the growing problem of youth unemployment in many African communities. Despite being energetic and capable, many young people spend their days idly because they cannot find stable jobs. This situation leads to frustration, dependency, and loss of hope among the youth.

Figure 2: Young graduate at home



Many educated young people complete college or university with high expectations of employment. However, due to limited job opportunities, they remain at home for months or even years after graduation. This gap between education and employment causes stress and discouragement.

Figure 3: Youths hawking



Figure 4: Boda boda guys



Because formal employment is scarce, many young people turn to informal jobs to survive. Although these jobs provide income, they are often unstable, low-paying, and lack job security or benefits. This reflects how youth are forced to settle for survival rather than career growth.

Figure 5: Closed kiosk



Figure 6: Closed shop



Small businesses are important sources of employment, but many close due to high taxes, low profits, and economic challenges. When businesses fail, job opportunities for young people decrease even further, worsening unemployment in the community.

Figure 7: Young person looking for a job



Figure 8: Searching for a job from home



The photos show young people actively searching for job opportunities online. Despite their efforts, competition is high, and opportunities are limited. It highlights the determination of youth as well as the difficulty of securing employment.

Figure 9: Young people playing



Figure 10: Young people gambling



Unemployment sometimes pushes young people into unproductive or risky activities such as gambling or substance abuse. Without meaningful engagement, some youth lose direction, which can lead to social problems in the community.

Figure 11: A Youth Skills Training Center



This image represents hope and possible solutions to youth unemployment. Skills training programs and vocational centers equip young people with practical abilities that can lead to self-employment and entrepreneurship.

Figure 12: A Young Entrepreneur Running a Small Business



Despite challenges, some young people create their own opportunities through small businesses. Youth entrepreneurship can help reduce unemployment and stimulate local economic growth when supported with funding and training.

Figure 13: Community Youth Meeting



Community programs and government initiatives play an important role in addressing youth unemployment. Such programs provide mentorship, financial support, and career guidance that can help young people transition into employment or business.

Figure 14: Youth working together



This final image symbolizes hope for the future. When young people are given opportunities, skills, and support, they can work together to build stronger communities and drive development. Investing in youth is investing in Africa's future.

Conclusion

The photographs in this essay demonstrate that youth unemployment is a complex problem with strong social and economic effects. Many young people are left idle despite having education, skills, and the desire to work. As a result, some are forced into informal jobs or underemployment, while others become discouraged and lose hope. This not only limits personal growth but also slows down community and national development (Ahmed, 2024; Mukasa, 2024).

However, the images also show that solutions are possible. Skills training, entrepreneurship education, and youth empowerment programs can help young people create their own opportunities and contribute positively to society (Mncwango & Adanlawo, 2025; Insights into Regional Development, 2024). Addressing youth unemployment requires joint efforts from governments, communities, and the youth themselves. When young people are supported and empowered, they become a powerful force for progress and transformation in Africa.

Reference List

- Ahmed, M. (2024). *Investigating graduate youth unemployment in Puntland: Causes, consequences, and solutions*. *East African Journal of Interdisciplinary Studies*, 7(1), 268-277.
- Insights into Regional Development. (2024). *Impact of entrepreneurship education on youth unemployment in South Africa*. *Insights into Regional Development*.
- Mncwango, S. I., & Adanlawo, E. F. (2025). *Reducing youth unemployment through entrepreneurship education interventions: The case of South Africa*. *Educational Process: International Journal*, 16, e2025261.
- Mukasa, A. (2024). *Youth jobs, skill and educational mismatches in Africa*. African Economic Conference.